

struggle to gain traction. Customers generally opt for convenience, and making a switch after several smartphones might not be easy," he says.

Having experienced the initial roadblocks, Indus Appstore's Dongre explains, "For developers, the biggest challenge will be the scale of distribution an app store can provide. Global competition has acquired users by virtue of being a pre-loaded application on every smartphone sold in India. Indian app stores will have to ensure that they solve for distribution to help developers acquire users through them."

Attracting developers to build for a home-grown platform is one problem, but getting the user to sideload the app store is another. It will require partnerships and a lot of capital. "How the app is going to be discovered is important. Unless you mandate the OEMs to pre-install a new app store, visibility will remain a challenge," says Pathak. He explains that most smartphone users are on the fourth or fifth smartphone of their lives. They are used to downloading apps from Apple's App Store and Google's Play Store since their first smartphone. Making a switch will not be easy.

"An Indian app store would require a fair, level playing field to compete with global tech giants. The entry of new players into the market is severely restricted as some of the existing players have signed opaque revenue-sharing agreements with OEMs," says Dongre. Regulators and policymakers need to prevent the abuse of dominance by these players through unfair practices, he adds. "Globally, regulators have started flagging these unfair practices and started working towards opening up the market."

THE WAY AHEAD

Some experts feel that the Indus Appstore is a step in the right direction. It has seen rapid adoption, with over 1 million installs within a month of its launch in February 2024. It of-

POINTS TO PONDER



THE DEVELOPER'S DILEMMA

While currently developers have to pay a certain fee to these two app stores, they still opt for them because downloads and discovery matter



INDIA STORY

Home-grown Indus Appstore saw 100,000 downloads within just 3 days of its launch; the store has 200,000 mobile apps under 40-plus categories



THE APP-LESS FUTURE

AI assistants could become the new interface of apps. These smart assistants may be able to meet localised needs of the users. Rabbit R1 and Humane AI devices envision this future

fers over 200,000 mobile apps and games across 45 categories.

It also fixes the issue of payment gateways. The app store allows app and game developers to choose any third-party payment gateway for in-app billing, charging no commission if an external payment gateway is used. To accelerate developer registrations, Indus is also offering zero listing fees to developers for one year. The app store also provides some bespoke solutions for the Indian demographic. It is available in 12 Indian languages, with voice search enabled and even a video-led discovery model.

While it aims to challenge the dominance of Google's Play Store and Apple's App Store, it is a long way from success. It will depend on the brand's ability to woo both developers and users, navigate the regulatory landscape, forge partnerships, and develop effective monetisation strategies. All this, while keeping an eye on a pivotal technology such as Gen AI.

The advent of AI is transforming our interaction with technology. It's creating a paradigm shift that could make conventional app stores less relevant. Two companies, Rabbit and Humane, are already imagining hardware without apps in the form we've come to expect. Meta's Ray-Ban smart glass is also trying to make the human-technology interface much less screen-based.

Pathak believes the future of smartphones will go beyond app stores. It may get replaced with Gen AI assistants, which will lead to a more customised user experience.

However, these advancements are still in their very early stages. Their impact on the future of app stores will depend on how well they meet user needs and how they evolve with the ever-changing tech landscape. Till then, both developers and users will have to depend on app stores. **BT**